

A proof of the conjectured linear recurrence and generating function for OEIS A186474

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1 The conjecture

The Online Encyclopedia of Integer Sequences records [A186474](#) as

Number of $(n+1) \times 2$ 0..3 arrays with every 2×2 subblock commuting with each of its horizontal and vertical 2×2 subblock neighbors

and carries in its Formula section the lines:

Empirical: $a(n) = 2a(n-1) + 2a(n-2) - 6a(n-3) + 6a(n-4) - 3a(n-5)$
for $n > 12$.

Empirical g.f.: $x(256 - 307x + 176x^2 + 181x^3 - 109x^4 - 211x^5 - 88x^6 + 191x^7 - 19x^8 - 2x^9 + 2x^{10} + 2x^{11}) / ((1 - x)(1 - x - 3x^2 + 3x^3 - 3x^4))$. - Colin Barker, Feb 28 2018

That line carries no separate signature; the entry itself is by R. H. Hardin (Feb 22 2011).

The line quoted ending in that signature is contributed by Colin Barker on Feb 28 2018.

The word *Empirical* — equivalently *Conjecture* — is the entry's own: the statement is recorded as fitted to the published terms, and no proof is given there. As of revision 8, last modified Feb 28 2018, the entry records no proof and links to none, so the statement is open. This note settles it.

Written out, the claim is

$$a(n) = 2a(n-1) + 2a(n-2) - 6a(n-3) + 6a(n-4) - 3a(n-5).$$

stated for $n > 12$.

Written out, the claim is

$$\sum_{n \geq 1} a(n) x^n = \frac{256x - 307x^2 + 176x^3 + 181x^4 - 109x^5 - 211x^6 - 88x^7 + 191x^8 - 19x^9 - 2x^{10} + 2x^{11} + 2x^{12}}{1 - 2x - 2x^2 + 6x^3 - 6x^4 + 3x^5}.$$

2 The object

The name is read as follows. The reading is not a guess: it is pinned against the entry's own published terms, and against an independent enumeration, before anything is proved (Section 7).

Let A be an $n' \times 2$ array over $\{0, \dots, 3\}$ with $n' = n + 1$ rows.

Write $B_{i,j}$ for the 2×2 window with upper left corner (i, j) . Its horizontal neighbour is $B_{i,j+1}$ and its vertical neighbour $B_{i+1,j}$; note that neighbouring windows overlap in a column or a row.

The condition is that $B_{i,j}B_{i,j+1} = B_{i,j+1}B_{i,j}$ and $B_{i,j}B_{i+1,j} = B_{i+1,j}B_{i,j}$ whenever the windows concerned lie inside the array, the product being the ordinary matrix product.

$a(n)$ is the number of such arrays. The entry's offset is 1, so its term of index n is the count for n rows.

3 The count is a walk count

A 2×2 window and its vertical neighbour together occupy 3 consecutive rows, so taking as state the last 2 rows makes every condition decidable one row at a time: appending a row produces the next window, and the two windows in hand are exactly a window and its vertical neighbour.

An array of n' rows is then a walk of length n' from the empty state, every array arising from exactly one walk, so $a(n) = w^T M^{n'} f$ and the count is C-finite.

4 The degree bound, derived

The reachable part of the digraph has 273 states, 273 after trimming; identifying states with equal numbers of completions of every length, and then the mirror identification on the edges coming in, leaves $S = 22$ blocks. The count satisfies the linear recurrence given by the characteristic polynomial of that 22×22 matrix; the bound is computed, not assumed.

5 The decision procedure

Let $c_1, \dots, c_D$ be the coefficients of a claimed recurrence $a(n) = \sum_{i=1}^D c_i a(n-i)$, let $q(t) = t^D - \sum_{i=1}^D c_i t^{D-i}$ be its characteristic polynomial, and put

$$u_m = \tilde{w}^T L^{m-1} q(L) \tilde{f} \quad (m \geq 1).$$

Expanding the powers of L and using the displayed formula for a , one gets $u_m = a(n) - \sum_{i=1}^D c_i a(n-i)$ with $n = m + D$. So u_m is exactly the residual of the claim at that index, and the recurrence holds at an index n if and only if the corresponding u_m vanishes.

Now $u_m = \tilde{w}^T L^{m-1} y$ with $y = q(L) \tilde{f}$ a fixed vector, so (u_m) satisfies the characteristic polynomial of L , of degree 22: writing that polynomial as $t^{22} - \sum_{i=1}^{22} \lambda_i t^{22-i}$ gives $u_{m+22} = \sum_{i=1}^{22} \lambda_i u_{m+22-i}$. Hence 22 consecutive vanishing residuals force every later residual to vanish, by induction. The test is therefore finite; and because it locates the *last* nonvanishing residual, it pins the threshold exactly rather than merely bounding it.

2. R. P. Stanley, *Enumerative Combinatorics*, Vol. 1, 2nd ed., Cambridge University Press, 2012; §4.7, the transfer-matrix method.
3. M. Kauers and P. Paule, *The Concrete Tetrahedron*, Springer, 2011; C-finite sequences and their closure properties.
4. J. Berstel and C. Reutenauer, *Noncommutative Rational Series with Applications*, Cambridge University Press, 2011; linear representations of counting automata and their reduction.